

The CTH Glyph System

Master Brief — Writing System, Atomic Strokes, Conceptual Glyphs, Faction Dialects, and the Inscription Grammar of the Chronoverse



FOR WOUND · TEMPORAL ECHOES / EMIT · V1.0

Contents

1. Overview — what the system is and what it does
2. Design principles — the five laws
3. The atomic alphabet — eleven strokes
4. Composition grammar — how atomics combine
5. The twelve conceptual glyphs — game-mechanic words
6. The master sigil — the unified inscription
7. The CTH equations — the system's load-bearing math
8. Faction dialects — four scripts, one alphabet
9. Writing in CTH — practical guide
10. Asset library — file names, color tokens, Typst usage

SECTION I

1. Overview

The CTH Glyph System is a constructed writing language used throughout the WOUND duology. It encodes the physics of Conjugate Temporal Harmonics — selfhood, time, memory, fracture — as a finite set of letterforms that compose into words, sentences, and equations. In the fiction, chronotech weapons

inscribe these glyphs to manipulate the Chronoverse; in the book, they appear as chapter sigils, mechanic markers, oracle stamps, and faction signatures.

The system rests on three commitments. **It is decomposable** — every conceptual glyph reduces to a readable arrangement of atomic strokes; a player who learns the alphabet can decode any inscription. **It is generative** — the chronotech, the player, and the designer can combine atomics into new compositions that mean exactly what their decomposition says they mean. **It is operational** — the CTH equations are not metaphors. The equations are statements written in this language, and inscribing them produces effects in the Chronoverse.

The aesthetic reference is industrial-runic: weighty geometric letterforms, distinct silhouettes at thumbnail size, no decoration beyond what the grammar requires. The system trades the occult-astrological feel of a single-template sigil set for the typographic clarity of a real alphabet.

SECTION II

2. The Five Design Laws

Every glyph in the system obeys these laws. Any new addition to the corpus must obey them.

LAW	RULE	WHY
1	Atomic primacy. Every glyph is either an atomic stroke or a readable composition of atomic strokes.	Decomposability. A player who learns 11 letters can read 12 words and infinitely many sentences.
2	Silhouette distinction. Every glyph must be uniquely identifiable at thumbnail size (24×24 px minimum).	Inline use in margins, on character sheets, in oracle tables. If you can't tell them apart small, the language fails at use.
3	Weighty geometric stroke. 5-unit stroke weight on a 100-unit canvas. Square line caps. Miter joins. No flourish.	Krakoan-industrial register. The glyphs are technical, not mystical. Production scaling requires consistency.
4	Composition by overlap or sequence. Glyphs combine either by overlapping into a unified mark (compound) or by reading side-by-side as a word (sequence).	Two composition modes is enough. More creates ambiguity; fewer prevents the language from encoding the equations.
	Dialect by uniform transform. Each faction's	Any glyph × any dialect renders automatically. The four factions can

5 dialect is one rule applied to every stroke. No sign any inscription in their hand
bespoke faction redrawings. without new artwork.

Construction grid: All glyphs render on a 100×100 viewBox. Default stroke weight is 5 units; auxiliary marks (dialect ticks, sub-strokes) use 2-3 units. `stroke-linecap="square"` and `stroke-linejoin="miter"` are mandatory — round caps soften the industrial register.

SECTION III

3. The Atomic Alphabet

Eleven strokes. These are the writing system at its foundation. Every composition in Section 5, every equation in Section 7, and every dialect inscription in Section 8 reduces to a sequence of these eleven forms.

A large, dark red uppercase letter 'T' composed of a horizontal bar and a vertical stem.A small, dark red lowercase letter 'tau' composed of a horizontal bar and a vertical stem.

TAU · TIME

The axis of time, displacement, the spine of selfhood. Appears in any concept involving temporal motion or persistence.

Horizontal bar (22,22)→(78,22); vertical descending to (50,82)

Two parallel, dark red horizontal bars stacked vertically.A small, dark red lowercase letter 'mu' composed of two stacked horizontal bars.

MU · MASS

Emotional mass, narrative weight, the gravitational charge of an event. Two stacked bars; reads as accumulated weight.

Two horizontal bars at y=38 and y=62



PSI · WAVEFORM

Identity as wave-state. The trident form encodes three converging modes resolving into a single carrier. The most complex atomic.

Three prongs at x=28/50/72 from y=18 to y=46; crossbar; central descent to y=84



IOTA · INTERVENTION

Choice, agency, deliberate action. The left-facing bracket. Pairs with C in equations where intent and consequence must both appear.

Left bracket: vertical x=38 from y=20 to y=80, with short top and bottom hooks rightward to x=58



CAUSALITY

Consequence, resistance, what the world pushes back with. The right-facing bracket. Always mirrors an I in equations of action and response.

Mirror of Iota: vertical x=62, hooks leftward to x=42



Ω

OMEGA · FIELD

The chronofield. The boundary inside which CTH variables interact. The only true circle in the alphabet — its uniqueness signals its scope.

Circle, center (50,50), radius 32



Δ

DELTA · FRACTURE

Change as breakage. The operator of transformation. Sharp apex, miter joins — points upward as a directional vector of disruption.

Triangle, apex (50,18), base (22,80)–(78,80)



ω

OMEGA-MINI · OSCILLATION

Micro-oscillation, vibration, the unit of frequency. The only true curve in the alphabet. Distinct from Ω by stroke type, not closure.

Bezier wave: M(18,65) Q(34,28)(50,50) Q(66,72)(82,35)



S

SIGMA · LIMIT

Collapse threshold, terminal state, the edge below which a system cannot operate. Inverse of Δ — points downward, miter apex at bottom.

```
Inverted-V polyline: (22,28)→(50,78)→(78,28)
```



R

RHO · MIRROR

Recursion, repetition, the operator of reflection. Two parallel verticals. Doubling R produces RECURSION — mirror of mirror.

```
Two parallels at x=35 and x=65, full height y=18 to y=82
```



E

EPSILON · ERASURE

Void, null, what was removed. The dashed horizontal stroke. Reads as absence-with-trace — something was there, and is no longer.

```
Dashed horizontal at y=50, stroke-dasharray "8 8"
```

SECTION IV

4. Composition Grammar

Atomics combine in two modes. Mode is determined by the relationship being

expressed.

Mode A — Compound (overlap)

When two atomics describe a single unified state — a bounded thing, a state-with-modifier — they overlap into one mark. ANCHOR is τ bounded by Ω — time inside field — and these overlap because the boundedness is part of the concept, not a sequence of actions. COLLAPSE is Ω with Δ slashing through it — the field is being broken, in one moment, as one act.

Compound example: ANCHOR



$\Omega + \tau \rightarrow \text{ANCHOR} \cdot \text{"time bounded by field"}$

Mode B — Sequence (side-by-side)

When two atomics describe a process — a thing acting on another thing, a thing repeated, a thing followed by an outcome — they read side-by-side as a word. ECHO is ΨR : waveform passed through a mirror. RECURSION is $R R$: mirror of mirror. Both are operations applied in time, not unified states.

Sequence example: ECHO



$\Psi R \rightarrow \text{ECHO} \cdot \text{"waveform passed through mirror"}$

Choosing the mode

The test is grammatical, not aesthetic: is the relationship between the two atomics *simultaneous* (compound) or *sequential* (sequence)? "Time inside field" is simultaneous — it has to be inside it for it to mean anything, in one instant. "Waveform passed through mirror" is sequential — the wave existed, then was reflected, then exists as something altered. When in doubt, default to compound for unified states and sequence for processes.

Operators

When writing equations (Section 7), four operators bridge between glyphs and standard math notation:

<code>=</code>	Equality — used in equations
<code>×</code>	Multiplication / convolution
<code>/</code>	Division / per-unit
<code>f()</code>	Function-of, applied to bracketed glyph string

Operators render in monospace serif at body size. They are not glyphs — they are typographic punctuation that joins glyphs into statements. The glyphs are the nouns and verbs; the operators are the conjunctions.

SECTION V

5. The Twelve Conceptual Glyphs

These are the working vocabulary of the system. Every game-mechanic concept resolves to one of these twelve compositions. Each is shown with its full render, its decomposition into atomics, and its meaning.



ANCHOR

IDENTITY TETHER

Time bounded by field. What keeps you real when reality drifts.

Compound · Ω + τ



MEMORY

RECOLLECTION

Waveform riding oscillation. Memory as a standing pattern that decays without renewal.

Compound · Ψ over ω



MOMENTUM

FORWARD VECTOR

Time toward fracture. Motion that costs something when arrested.

Sequence · τ Δ



PARADOX

REALITY DAMAGE

Waveform fractured. The wave still resolves, but the resolution contradicts itself.

Compound · Ψ through Δ



ECHO

DISPLACED WAVEFORM

Waveform passed through mirror. The original wave still exists; this is the copy.

Sequence · Ψ R



DRIFT

LOSING ALIGNMENT

Time tapering toward limit. The slow approach to a state from which no return is possible.

Vertical sequence · τ over S



RIPPLE

DISTURBANCE SPREADING

Three oscillations in sequence. A single event propagating outward through CTH.

Sequence · ω ω ω



COLLAPSE

NODE FAILURE

Field violently fractured. Single event; no propagation; the boundary itself fails.

Compound · Ω through Δ



RECURSION

TIME FOLDED BACK

Mirror of mirror. The same configuration returning. Loop Authority's desired state.

Sequence · R R



NULL

ERASURE

The atomic E rendered at full size, standing alone. What was; is not.

Solo · E



BURDEN

EMOTIONAL WEIGHT

Three masses stacked. Accumulation of charge that cannot be discharged without cost.

Compound stack · $\mu \mu \mu$



RENDITION

A LIFE REWRITTEN

Waveform erased; waveform rewritten. The first version still leaves a dashed trace between.

Sequence · $\Psi \text{ E } \Psi$

SECTION VI

6. The Master Sigil

The Master Sigil contains every CTH variable bounded by the field. It is the unified equation written as a single mark: τ , μ , Ψ , I , C , all inside Ω .



$\tau + \mu + \Psi + I + C$ bounded by Ω

Because the Master Sigil contains the entire alphabet, it is the only inscription that cannot be reduced further. It is the upper bound of what the language can encode in one mark. The chronotech does not inscribe it because inscribing it would mean producing the entire CTH equation simultaneously — which is what the First Scar was.

Production rule: The Master Sigil appears in WOUND exactly three times. Cover (intact). emiT title page (one terminal missing — first sign of damage). Saul Files closing page (one terminal replaced by the MEMORY glyph — the cycle made visible). Every additional appearance dilutes the move. Treat the sigil like a load-bearing word: used sparingly, never decorated.

SECTION VII

7. The CTH Equations

Four equations describe the load-bearing physics of the Chronoverse. Each is shown in standard mathematical notation and in glyph form. The glyph form is what the chronotech inscribes; the inscription itself is the operation.

EQUATION 1 · THE WAVE EQUATION

$$\Delta \Psi = f(\Delta \tau \times \mu)$$

$$\Delta \Psi = f(\Delta \tau \times \mu)$$

Reading: The change in waveform equals a function of fractured time multiplied by mass. The fundamental equation of identity drift — the more time fractures and the more mass accumulates, the more the waveform changes.

Inscription effect: Loop Authority etches this on retrieval cuffs. Properly inscribed, it stabilizes a target's waveform during transport. Improperly inscribed — Δ replaced by E — it erases them.

EQUATION 2 · THE COLLAPSE THRESHOLD

$$S = (\mu \times \Psi_p) / \Delta\Theta^2$$

$$\nabla = (\mu \times \Psi_p) / (\Delta\Theta^2)$$

Reading: The collapse threshold equals mass times parent waveform, divided by squared field-erasure. Determines the moment a Coherence trajectory cannot be reversed. Note: $\Delta\Theta$ — the fractured field — composes as Ω with E running through it (Θ).

Inscription effect: Scionfall ritualists carve this into the Graceful Severance blade. The blade does not kill — it inscribes the collapse threshold on the target, and the target's own waveform completes the equation.

EQUATION 3 · THE RIPPLE PROPAGATION

$$R = k(\Delta\mu \times I) / \Psi_\ell$$

$$R = k(\Delta\mu \times I) / \Psi_\ell$$

Reading: Ripple propagation equals a constant times fractured-mass and intervention, divided by local waveform. The smaller your local waveform, the further your actions ripple. Chronoclast doctrine.

Inscription effect: Chronoclasts tattoo this on their inner forearms. The smaller and more local their identity becomes, the larger their effect on the timestream. Inverse self-importance, made mechanical.

$$\Psi_e(t) = \sum a_n e^{(i\omega_n t)}$$

$$\Psi_e(t) = \sum a_n \cdot e^{(i \omega_n t)}$$

Reading: An Echo's waveform at time t equals the sum over all component frequencies of their amplitudes times the exponential of their oscillation. The wave-mechanical formal definition of an Echo as a superposition rather than a singular self.

***Inscription effect:** The Church inscribes this on its temple walls. Their doctrine holds that an Echo who reads the equation while understanding it ceases to be the original; the equation makes them retroactively true.*

SECTION VIII

8. Faction Dialects

Each of the four factions writes the same alphabet differently. The dialect is one transformation applied uniformly to every stroke. Same letters, same words, different scripts — the way the same English sentence can appear in serif Times, monospace Courier, blackletter Old English, and handwritten cursive without changing meaning.

The rule below demonstrates each dialect on Ψ (the most complex atomic, so the rule is most visible). The same transformation applies to every other atomic and every composition, automatically.



Base Ψ

No transformation



Authority

Every stroke doubled
 Church Cross-mark on every terminus
 Scionfall Every stroke dashed
 Chronoclasts 15° clockwise rotation

Dialect transformation rules

Faction	Rule	SVG Implementation	Reading
Loop Authority	Every stroke doubled	Each <code><line></code> / <code><path></code> rendered as two parallel strokes 4 units apart, weight reduced to 3	Redundancy as control. The Authority writes twice because the first inscription must be auditable.
Church	Cross-mark at every terminus	Small perpendicular tick (weight 2, length 10) at every stroke endpoint	Ritual scarification of the letters themselves. Each word bears the marks of the priesthood that wrote it.
Scionfall	Every stroke dashed	<code>stroke-dasharray="4 4"</code> applied uniformly	The fading. Scionfall writes as if the inscription is already disappearing — as if the speaker is already gone.

Chronoclasts	15° clockwise rotation of entire glyph	<code><g transform="rotate(15 50 50)"></code> wrapping all strokes	The tilt. Chronoclasts write off-axis because their position is off-axis. The reader must turn their head to read it.
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Generalization: Any glyph can render in any dialect by wrapping its body in the transformation rule. The pipeline is: base glyph SVG → apply dialect transform → output dialect SVG. No bespoke per-faction artwork is required for any composition. Each dialect adds approximately 1 line of code to the asset pipeline.

SECTION IX

9. Writing in CTH

Composing new concepts

A concept the system does not yet name can be written by composing atomics. The procedure:

1. State the concept in plain English. Example: "the memory of a fracture."
2. Identify the atomic components. Memory = Ψ ω ; fracture = Δ . The concept therefore involves three atomics.
3. Determine the relationship. Is the fracture *inside* the memory (compound), or did the memory *follow* the fracture (sequence)? If the former, render as MEMORY with Δ overlapped. If the latter, render as Δ followed by MEMORY.
4. Test the inscription. If a reader who knows the alphabet can recover the original concept by decomposition, the inscription is valid. If they cannot, the composition is ambiguous and needs refinement.

Writing equations

Equations are sequences of glyphs joined by operators. The glyphs are the variables; the operators (=, ×, /, f()) are typographic punctuation. To write a new equation:

1. State the relationship in standard math. Example: "the rate of paradox accumulation equals burden times intervention."
2. Replace each variable with its glyph composition. Δ PARADOX = BURDEN × I, with PARADOX rendered as Ψ -through- Δ and BURDEN as triple- μ .
3. Render glyphs at uniform size (40px standard for inline equations; 56px for displayed equations).
4. Set operators in monospace serif at 1.3rem, vertically centered with the glyphs.

The chronotech inscription

In-fiction, the chronotech weaponizes the alphabet by inscribing glyph sequences directly onto matter, energy, or waveforms. The inscription *is* the operation: writing ANCHOR onto an object bounds that object to its time-coordinate; writing COLLAPSE onto a field forces field failure; writing the Wave Equation onto a retrieval cuff stabilizes the wearer.

The chronotech does not interpret the inscription. The inscription executes itself by being inscribed. This is why the equations must be precisely written: a missing terminal on a Ψ doesn't render the inscription harmless; it renders it different. Loop Authority's Doctrine 7.4.b governs which atomics may be inscribed by which rank of operator. Most field operatives can inscribe single-atomic protections (Ω alone for warding; τ alone for navigation). Only Senior Loopwrights are licensed for full equation inscriptions.

Canonical inscriptions to feature in the book

INSCRIPTION	GLYPH FORM	WHERE IT APPEARS
Loop Authority warding	Ω with τ centered (i.e., ANCHOR in Authority dialect)	Retrieval cuffs, Authority field offices, induction tattoos
Church benediction	Equation 4 in Church dialect, etched into temple lintels	Church of the Holy Second sanctuaries, ordination scrolls
Scionfall Graceful Severance	Equation 2 in Scionfall dialect, blade engraving	Ritual blades, severance documents
Chronoclast tattoo	Equation 3 in Chronoclast dialect, inner forearm	Chronoclast member identification
The First Scar inscription (the Master Sigil unmade)	Master Sigil with one atomic replaced by E	Appendix H (Saul Files) closing page only

SECTION X

10. Asset Library

File naming convention

PREFIX	CATEGORY	EXAMPLES
atom_	Atomic strokes (11 files)	atom_tau.svg , atom_mu.svg , atom_psi.svg
	Conceptual glyphs (12 files)	concept_anchor.svg , concept_memory.svg ,

concept_		concept_paradox.svg
sigil_	Master and reserved sigils	sigil_master.svg
dialect_	Dialect demonstrations (4 files, on Ψ base)	dialect_authority_psi.svg , dialect_church_psi.svg

Color tokens

All SVGs use `stroke="currentColor"` and render in whatever color the parent context provides. Recommended tokens from the WOUND design bible:

CONTEXT	TOKEN	HEX	USE
Chen pages (cream)	EL-Burgundy	#6B3232	Primary stroke color for all conceptual glyphs
Chen pages, mechanical	EL-Forest	#3D5A47	Anchor/Coherence procedure markers
Chen pages, faded	EL-Annotation	#8B7355	Late-insertion ghost glyphs, staged variants
Alan pages (void)	AL-Electric	#D4B886	All glyphs render in gold on Alan ground
Faction signage	SF-Paradox	#A03030	Warning/intervention inscriptions only

Typst usage

```
// Inline glyph at body-text size, inheriting page color
#image("glyphs/concept_anchor.svg", width: 6mm)

// Glyph in burgundy regardless of context
#text(fill: rgb("#6B3232"))[
  #image("glyphs/concept_anchor.svg", width: 6mm)
]

// Chapter sigil at chapter opener (large, centered)
#align(center)[
  #text(fill: rgb("#6B3232"))[
    #image("glyphs/concept_memory.svg", width: 28mm)
  ]
]

// Margin marker (small, in the outer margin column)
#place(right, dx: 22mm, dy: 0pt)[
  #text(fill: rgb("#6B3232"))[
    #image("glyphs/concept_anchor.svg", width: 6mm)
  ]
]
```

```
// Equation render
#align(center)[
  #image("glyphs/atom_delta.svg", width: 8mm)
  #image("glyphs/atom_psi.svg", width: 8mm)
  #h(0.4em) = #h(0.4em) f(
  #image("glyphs/atom_delta.svg", width: 8mm)
  #image("glyphs/atom_tau.svg", width: 8mm)
  #h(0.4em) × #h(0.4em)
  #image("glyphs/atom_mu.svg", width: 8mm)
  )
]
```

Size hierarchy in the book

CONTEXT	SIZE	NOTES
Chapter sigil (centered above title)	28mm	Largest production size
Section sigil (within a chapter)	14mm	For subsection divisions
Inline margin marker	6mm	The workhorse size; outer margin column
Equation inline glyph	8–10mm	Matches body-text x-height plus padding
Late-insertion ghost	5mm	Slightly under-saturation for "haunting" effect
Faction dialect plate (Appendix A)	20mm	Four-dialect comparison spread

Production checklist before layout

1. Verify all 28 SVG assets render correctly in your target software (Typst, InDesign, Affinity Publisher).
2. Confirm `stroke="currentColor"` is respected by your renderer; if not, replace with explicit fill hex before deployment.
3. Test thumbnail-size legibility: every glyph at 24px should still be identifiable. If two glyphs blur into each other at that size, the system has failed Law 2.
4. Test the dialect transform pipeline: produce ANCHOR in all four dialects and confirm the same rule applies cleanly to a complex composition.
5. Lock the Master Sigil to its three sacred locations only. Any other appearance dilutes the move.

